

Deserving winners: on South Africa's win at Lord's

South Africa reached the **summit** in Tests after a history of failures

It was a long wait that **culminated** in **delight**. Until Saturday's high at Lord's, South Africa was often **resigned to playing second fiddle** in the big cricketing contests. The **Proteas** always had strong units and some great players, but a **stumble** in the climactic stages of ICC events **became** the norm. Finally, when Temba Bavuma's men **prevailed over defending champion** Australia in the World Test Championship's **summit clash** in London, many ghosts were **laid to rest**. South Africa's previous ICC **silverware** was the title in the Wills International Cup at Dhaka in 1998. That tournament became the **precursor** to the Champions Trophy and even as this particular event grew, South Africa **regressed** with **comical** run-outs, dropped catches and **miscalculation** of rain-rules often becoming **steep** hurdles. To **concede** a first innings lead and then to chase 282 in a **grim** fourth innings **pursuit** was never easy, but a **dogged** Bavuma and **centurion** Aiden Markram ensured that the early **strikes** of **spearhead** Kagiso Rabada **were** never wasted. The **trio** performed **admirably** and it was also a **reflection** of the **diverse** ethnic groups that constitute South Africa, often called the **Rainbow Nation**. This fact and the need for unity was **reiterated** through Bavuma's **impassioned** post-match speech. The **skipper** truly led from the front.

Cricket needed this result as **whispers** of the 'Big Three' of India, Australia and England, **calling the shots** and **elbowing out** other opposition in the overall scheduling have been doing the rounds. Besides applying **salve** to a country searching for cricketing glory, the South African **triumph** also revealed that other teams can acquire the champions' **halo**. To **get past** Pat Cummins and his men is always tough but Bavuma and his troops held firm in an **engrossing** Test. Australia has a **potent** attack that never allows batters to settle, and to **counter** this and emerge on top is a **tribute** to an **outfit** that was **acutely** conscious about past failures. Even last year, Markram's men slipped in the ICC T20 World Cup final against India. From being tagged as **chokers** and to then become the number one Test **squad** is a **stupendous** achievement. South Africa never had it easy in cricket as its previous **apartheid** policy rightly left it **isolated** from sport. The comeback was **gradual** from the 1990s and then the match-fixing crisis that consumed Hansie Cronje, was a **mighty blow**. To **put** all these **setbacks** and losses **behind** them needed a special effort and it was this that Bavuma and his men provided at cricket's **spiritual** home.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.
- **Proteas** (noun) – the nickname for the South African national cricket team

Vocabulary

1. **Deserve** (verb) – merit, earn, warrant, justify, be worthy of योग्य होना
2. **Summit** (noun) – peak, top, apex, pinnacle, zenith शिखर
3. **Culminate** (verb) – conclude, finish, climax, result, terminate चरम सीमा पर पहुँचना
4. **Delight** (noun) – joy, pleasure, happiness, elation, bliss प्रसन्नता
5. **Resign** (to) (verb) – accept, yield, submit, surrender, acquiesce मान लेना (अवश्यम्भावी रूप में)
6. **Play second fiddle** (phrase) – be subordinate, support, assist, follow, back गौण भूमिका निभाना
7. **Stumble** (noun) – setback, blunder, error, lapse, misstep ठोकर / चूक
8. **Prevail** (over) (verb) – triumph, succeed, overcome, conquer, win पराजित करना
9. **Defending champion** (noun) – a person or team that has won a competition, like a sports tournament, in the past and is now participating in the same competition again to try and retain their title. गत विजेता
10. **Summit clash** (noun) – final match
11. **Lay to rest** (phrase) – settle, resolve, dispel, end, conclude समाप्त करना
12. **Silverware** (noun) – trophy, prize, award, cup, accolade विजयी ट्रॉफी
13. **Precursor** (noun) – forerunner, predecessor, antecedent, pioneer, harbinger पूर्ववर्ती
14. **Regress** (verb) – deteriorate, decline, worsen, relapse, backslide पतन होना
15. **Comical** (adjective) – funny, amusing, humorous, laughable, ridiculous हास्यास्पद
16. **Miscalculation** (noun) – error, mistake, misjudgment, slip, oversight ग़लत आकलन
17. **Steep** (adjective) – difficult, intense, sharp, excessive, formidable कठिन / अधिक
18. **Concede** (verb) – yield, surrender, admit, forfeit, grant स्वीकार करना (हार)
19. **Grim** (adjective) – bleak, harsh, stern, severe, gloomy गंभीर
20. **Pursuit** (noun) – chase, quest, attempt, endeavour, striving प्रयास
21. **Dogged** (adjective) – having or showing tenacity and grim persistence. हठी
22. **Centurion** (adjective) – hundred-scorer (cricket-specific), ton-maker, century-maker, top-scorer, batsman with 100+ runs शतकवीर
23. **Spearhead** (adjective) – Captain, कप्तान

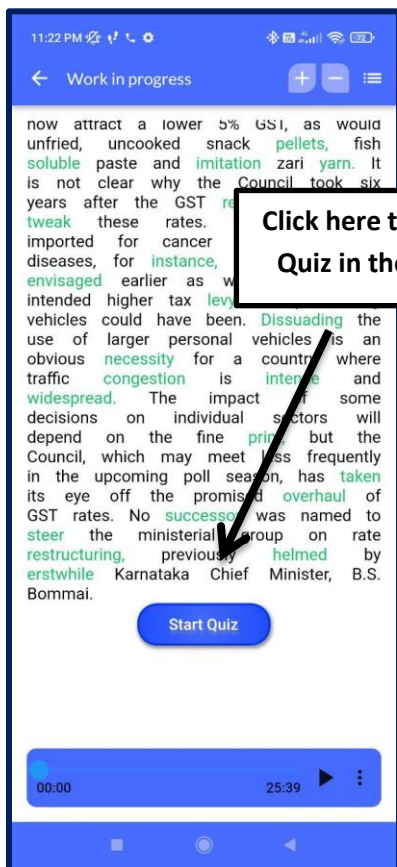
24. **Trio** (adjective) – threesome, trio-group, triad, threesome team, threesome unit
त्रय / तीन लोगों का समूह
25. **Admirably** (adverb) – commendably, excellently, notably, wonderfully, laudably
प्रशंसनीय रूप से
26. **Reflection** (noun) – representation, indication, expression, embodiment, mirror प्रतिबिंब
27. **Diverse** (adjective) – varied, different, mixed, assorted, heterogeneous विविध
28. **Rainbow Nation** (noun) – a multiracial or multicultural country (used especially of South Africa in the post-apartheid era).
बहुजातीय देश (दक्षिण अफ्रीका के लिए विशेष रूप से)
29. **Reiterate** (verb) – repeat, restate, emphasize, affirm, stress दोहराना
30. **Impassioned** (adjective) – emotional, fervent, heartfelt, intense, passionate
भावनात्मक
31. **Skipper** (adjective) – captain, leader, head, chief, commander कप्तान
32. **Whisper** (noun) – rumour, gossip, murmur, hearsay, buzz फुसफुसाहट / अफवाह
33. **Call the shots** (phrase) – control, decide, dominate, command, take charge नियंत्रण रखना
34. **Elbow out** (phrasal verb) – push aside, oust, displace, exclude, edge out बाहर निकालना
35. **Salve** (noun) – comfort, balm, relief, solace, soothing remedy मरहम / सांत्वना
36. **Triumph** (noun) – victory, win, success, conquest, achievement जीत
37. **Halo** (noun) – aura, glory, prestige, fame, distinction आभा / गौरव
38. **Get past** (phrase) – overcome, defeat, surpass, beat, move beyond पार पाना
39. **Engrossing** (adjective) – absorbing, captivating, compelling, fascinating, riveting दिलचस्प
40. **Potent** (adjective) – powerful, strong, effective, forceful, dominant प्रभावशाली
41. **Counter** (verb) – oppose, resist, tackle, confront, defy मुकाबला करना
42. **Tribute** (noun) – homage, salute, praise, honour, recognition सम्मान
43. **Outfit** (noun) – team, group, unit, squad, crew दल / टीम
44. **Acutely** (adverb) – sharply, intensely, severely, strongly, deeply तीव्र रूप से
45. **Choker** (noun) – underperformer, loser, failure under pressure, struggler, faller
दबाव में असफल होने वाला खिलाड़ी

46. **Squad** (noun) – team, group, unit, side, lineup टीम
47. **Stupendous** (adjective) – amazing, astonishing, remarkable, phenomenal, incredible जबरदस्त
48. **Apartheid** (noun) – racial segregation, discrimination, separation, racism, inequality रंगभेद
49. **Isolated** (adjective) – separated, excluded, cut off, detached, alone अलग-थलग
50. **Gradual** (adjective) – slow, steady, progressive, incremental, continuous धीरे-धीरे होने वाला
51. **Mighty** (adjective) – great, powerful, strong, massive, formidable बहुत बड़ा / शक्तिशाली
52. **Blow** (noun) – setback, shock, tragedy, misfortune, defeat झटका
53. **Put something behind** (phrasal verb) – overcome, forget, move on, leave behind, rise above पीछे छोड़ देना
54. **Setback** (noun) – obstacle, failure, hurdle, defeat, impediment बाधा
55. **Spiritual** (adjective) – sacred, soulful, inner, divine, holy पवित्र

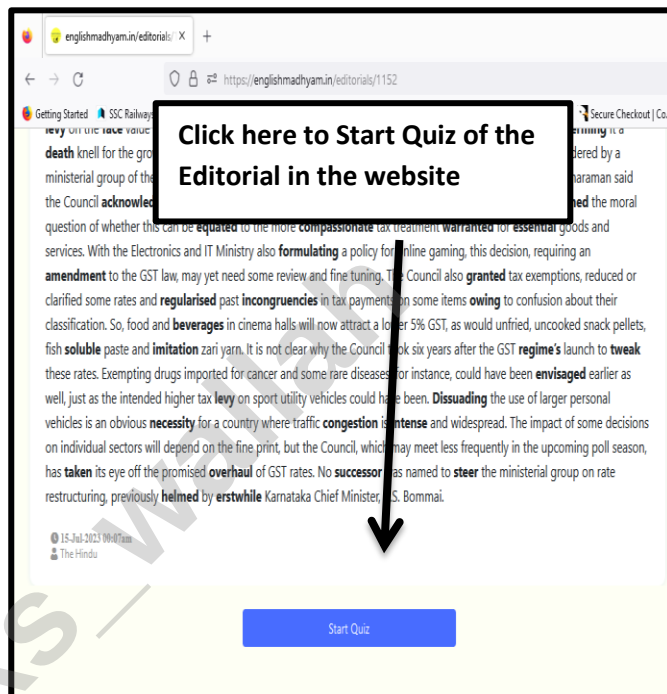
Summary of the Editorial

1. South Africa clinched the World Test Championship title by defeating Australia at Lord's, marking a historic cricketing triumph.
2. This win ended a long wait for major ICC silverware since their 1998 Wills International Cup victory.
3. Historically, South Africa had strong teams but often failed at critical ICC moments, developing a reputation for choking.
4. Their performance was marked by comical run-outs, dropped catches, and rule miscalculations in past tournaments.
5. In this Test, South Africa overcame a first innings deficit and chased down 282 in the fourth innings — a tough task.
6. Captain Temba Bavuma led from the front with resilience, supported by a century from Aiden Markram.
7. Early breakthroughs by Kagiso Rabada were crucial in building the foundation for the comeback win.
8. The trio's contribution reflected the diverse ethnic makeup of the team and South African society — the "Rainbow Nation".
9. Bavuma's emotional post-match speech highlighted unity and pride, reinforcing the significance of inclusivity in sport.
10. The victory challenged the narrative dominated by the 'Big Three' — India, Australia, and England — in cricket governance and scheduling.
11. South Africa's success sent a strong message that other teams can rise and become champions, not just traditional powerhouses.
12. The win was especially impressive given Australia's formidable bowling attack that usually stifles opposition.
13. The team drew motivation from previous heartbreaks, such as the 2024 ICC T20 World Cup final loss to India.
14. From being known as "chokers" to Test champions, the transformation is a testament to their grit and perseverance.
15. Overcoming historical scars like apartheid isolation and the Hansie Cronje match-fixing scandal, this victory was deeply symbolic and redemptive.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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